As I was the only colonel commanding a battalion in the entire division, my performance was being watched. There was no option but to produce results. Besides doing quite well in professional competitions, we worked hard to create excellent teams in shooting and cross country. We achieved a top-ten finish in the inter-battalion cross-country competition. Subsequently, my best long-distance runner, Naik Parshuram Chaugule, won four golds and was declared the best athlete of the division. Within two years Chaugule represented India in an international cross-country competition in Australia.

During this period, we nearly had a flare-up with Pakistan. It was an escalation of tensions due to Exercise 'Brass Tacks' being conducted in Rajasthan. All of a sudden, we received orders to move by air from Hyderabad to Delhi. Over two nights in February 1987, we were airlifted to Delhi. Our formation was earmarked as an Army HQ reserve in case of an emergency. During the stay in Delhi for about six months, my name came up for an interview for an assignment abroad as a defence attaché. Interestingly, it was soon after Holi, when a basketball match is traditionally held in the Fifth Royal between the officers and junior commissioned officers. Unfortunately, I had a fall on the cemented court and fractured my right forearm. It was a compound fracture and there were cracks on both the radius and the ulna. I remained with a plaster cast for about ten weeks. A specially stitched uniform was provided to me for the interview, and it was the first time I saluted with my left hand. I was selected to be our first defence attaché in Algeria. My sportfulness must have enhanced my interview scores! Twenty-three years of regimental soldiering came to an end with a warm and befitting farewell from the Fifth Royal in July 1987. Hereafter, in a broader perspective, I would be serving the Indian Army and not a particular regiment. I joined the army to be a soldier and on commissioning, my aim was to become the commanding officer of my 'paltan'. I had already commanded my own 9 Maratha LI and the Fifth Royal, and that too for a period of almost four-and-a-half years. 'What more could one ask for. Anything else that comes my way now shall be a bonus,' I said to myself.